

**a** AI Highlight ▾

I asked my dad about sex when I was five, and he briefly explained:: “Sex is what you do when you are older and you find a friend you want to have children with.”

It was a good tip, but it left out the whole question of romance: why that friend rather than one of the others, what problems people have in relationships, and how to prevent or handle them.

I can't expect my dad to have developed a whole guide to all that, because that wasn't his main mission. So I ended up learning most of it the hard way, and this is what I'd like to pass on to my kids, although by the time they read it, the existence of natural humans, romance, love, might be long forgotten, for all I know.

This guide isn't universally applicable for everyone even now, since it comes from my particular life experience (including influences I've had from friends & research). I'm a straight man, and I'm writing from relationships I've had with women, so she and her are going to show up a lot. Most of this has nothing specifically to do with being male or straight. The Primal Attraction section is the exception, because there I'm specifically talking about the man-woman dynamic I've actually lived.

What we mean by “love” ♥

English isn't a scientific language when it comes to love. This leads to a lot of romantic confusion because we don't have one word for one meaning.

One meaning is selfless love—what contemplative traditions call agape, metta, loving-kindness, divine love, and so forth. In Buddhist metta practice you sit there wishing, may they be well, may they be safe, may they be happy. It's not about them being yours.

Then we use the same word for romantic love (eros): I want you. I want your attention and your body. I want to be special to you, and I want our lives tangled up together. I don't think there's anything fake or shameful about this.

A good relationship must have both kinds of love at once. Too often, the trouble is there's a whole lot of I want you and hardly any I want you to be happy.

Most people fail this test: what would I want if she herself thought she'd be happier with somebody else? But if they can get past the initial horror, the conflict starts to fall apart. Being wanted is part of what makes me want someone.



Overview



Detail